

MNS CONSULTING

UNDERSTANDING THE DYNAMICS OF COVERING AND MONITORING HIGH-RISK EVENTS AND POLITICAL PROTESTS

An OODA Loop and Risk-Assessment Framework for Field Analysts

LIVED CASE STUDY: UN GENERAL ASSEMBLY 81, NEW YORK CITY, SEPTEMBER 2026

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Field Operations | Political Risk | Civil Unrest Monitoring

Executive Overview

This framework is designed for field analysts covering political events, demonstrations, counter-demonstrations, diplomatic gatherings, and developing civil unrest. It combines the Observe-Orient-Decide-Act (OODA) decision cycle with a layered risk-assessment model and a behavior-based public-order classification system. The intent is to give analysts a disciplined way to distinguish political intensity from actual interaction risk while maintaining personal safety and evidentiary integrity.

The model is grounded in M. Nuri Shakoor's contemporaneous field notes, photographs, and video observations from UN General Assembly 81 in New York City in September 2026.[1] It also incorporates a four-phase public-order framework spanning Passive Assembly, Expressive Friction, Dynamic Confrontation, and Violent Disorder/Riot.[2] The OODA cycle provides the cognitive structure for continuously updating the analyst's field picture in a fast-changing environment.[3]

The principal lesson from UNGA 81 is that political events should be analyzed as evolving systems rather than photographed as static crowds. The analyst's task is to observe behavior before inferring intent, orient on relationships and trajectory, decide according to evidence and safety, act conservatively, and immediately restart the loop.

FIELD DOCTRINE

Observe behavior before judging intent. Orient on relationships, space, and trajectory. Decide according to evidence and safety. Act conservatively, preserve access, and immediately restart the loop.

1. Purpose and Operating Principles

The framework supports analysts who must simultaneously collect political information, monitor changes in public-order conditions, protect themselves, and preserve a defensible evidence trail. It is not a policing doctrine and does not direct law-enforcement tactics. It is a field-analysis methodology.

The analyst maintains two separate mental models: mobilization intensity and interaction risk. Large crowds, loud chanting, coordinated apparel, or severe rhetoric may indicate strong mobilization but do not by themselves establish violence. Interaction risk increases when hostile or mutually antagonistic actors converge, separation distance decreases, egress is constrained, crowd compression increases, or security actors shift from facilitation toward physical separation.

Every field judgment should be traceable to one of three evidence layers: direct observation, contemporaneous analyst assessment, or externally reported information. Claims printed on signs and statements made by participants should be treated as attributed political claims until independently corroborated.

2. The Integrated OODA-Risk Model

Boyd's OODA loop is a continuous decision cycle of observing, orienting, deciding, and acting. Air University describes it as a process for functioning in complex, fast-changing environments, with observation and orientation feeding decisions that are then tested through action.[3]

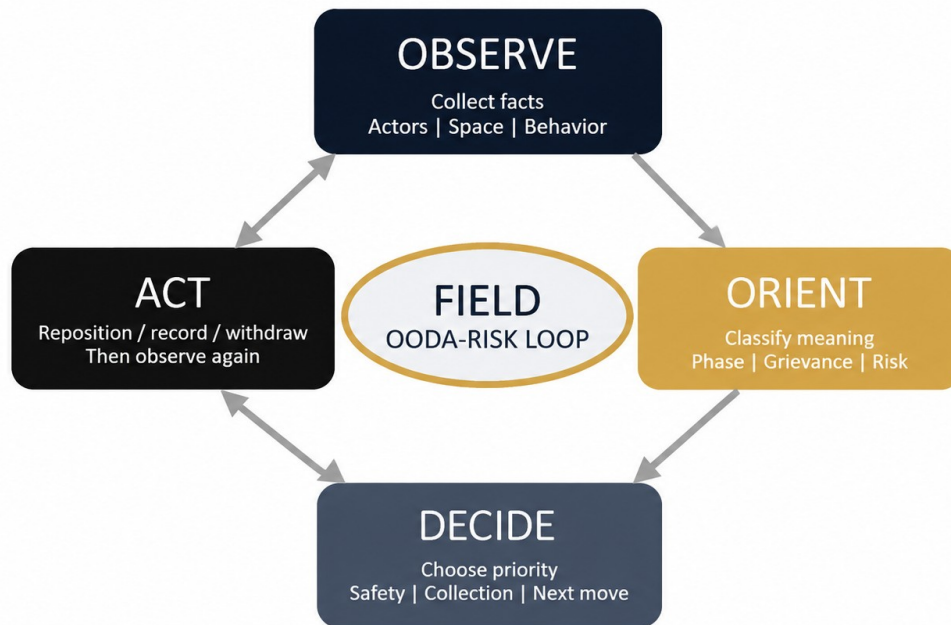


Figure 1. MNS Consulting field analyst adaptation of the OODA loop for monitoring high risk events.

2.1 Observe

Establish the field picture before interpreting it. Record actors, messages, space, behavior, security posture, movement, media activity, and available egress. Write what is seen before writing what it means.

2.2 Orient

Convert observations into meaning. Identify the event type, public-order phase, principal grievance, political target, legitimacy frame, organizational structure, counter-presence, and direction of risk. Orientation should actively test alternate explanations rather than merely confirming the analyst's first impression.

2.3 Decide

Select the next collection and safety action. Decide whether to hold position, reposition, widen standoff distance, preserve an exit route, follow movement, change from still photography to video, document security changes, or terminate collection.

2.4 Act

Execute the selected action proportionately. The action produces new information, which begins the next OODA cycle. Field analysis is continuous, not episodic.

3. Observe: The Seven-Domain Field Picture

Domain	What the analyst records
Actors	Protesters, counter-protesters, organizers, media, police, private security, political

Domain	What the analyst records
	supporters, bystanders.
Message	Slogans, grievances, targets, demands, symbols, named individuals, organizational branding.
Space	Density, barriers, streets, entrances, choke points, police lines, safe routes, egress.
Behavior	Chanting, marching, filming, debating, arguing, pushing, fighting, dispersing, regrouping.
Security	Police numbers, posture, reinforcement, barricades, separation tactics, visible emergency assets.
Movement	Arrival, convergence, fragmentation, dispersal, relocation, re-formation.
Information Environment	Phones, livestreams, journalists, influencers, movement media, amplification behavior.

4. Orient: Event and Crowd Classification

The analyst should classify two things separately: the event form and the immediate crowd phase. Event form describes what the gathering is doing. Crowd phase describes its current interaction condition. The reference framework distinguishes lawful rallies and demonstrations from civil disobedience, civil unrest, and riot based on behavior, disruption, and violence, not political viewpoint.[2]

Phase	Primary indicators	Risk meaning	UNGA 81 illustration
Passive Assembly	Open spacing, ambient discussion, periodic chants.	Low interaction risk unless conditions change.	Portions of the Liberia debate environment.
Expressive Friction	Shared identity, loud chanting, directional clustering, visible out-group orientation.	Moderate; monitor convergence and egress.	Early/mid Guinea mobilization; some Liberia argumentation.
Dynamic Confrontation	Directed verbal hostility, crowd compression, hostile proximity, targeted police separation.	High; trajectory and safe positioning become priorities.	Peak Guinea protest/counter-protest convergence.
Violent Disorder / Riot	Sustained destructive violence, projectiles,	Critical.	Not supported as the overall classification by

Phase	Primary indicators	Risk meaning	UNGA 81 illustration
	barricades, attacks on people/property/infrastructure.		the reviewed UNGA 81 evidence.

5. Risk Architecture

5.1 Field Interaction-Risk State

The 1-5 field state is a situational temperature. It is designed for rapid reassessment and should be recorded as a trajectory, not as a static label.



Figure 2. MNS Consulting 1-5 field interaction-risk ladder.

5.2 Formal 5×5 Operational Risk

The rapid field state should be paired with a conventional likelihood × impact assessment. This keeps immediate crowd temperature separate from consequences to the analyst, participants, bystanders, access routes, diplomatic/security operations, and public order.

- Likelihood indicators: cross-group proximity, crowd compression, hostility, unpredictable movement/re-formation, and security-control gaps.
- Impact indicators: analyst safety, participant/bystander harm, access disruption, diplomatic/security effects, and broader public-order consequences.
- Risk score: Likelihood × Impact. A high interaction state can coexist with a different formal risk score depending on consequence and exposure.

6. Decision Triggers and Analyst Actions

Trigger	Analyst response
Counter-protest arrives	Reassess proximity, escape routes, and whether the collection position is becoming a

	convergence point.
Police reinforcement	Document posture change; determine whether separation, containment, extraction, or dispersal is underway.
Physical contact	Increase standoff; switch collection priority from messaging to interaction dynamics and safety.
Route change	Identify whether movement is dispersal, relocation, or deliberate movement toward a new target.
Crowd fragmentation	Track subgroups separately; do not assume event termination.
Secondary-location movement	Reassess political significance of destination and likelihood of re-formation.
Egress narrows	Reposition before crowd geometry forces the decision.

THE DISPERSAL RULE

Never assume dispersal means termination. Distinguish dispersal, fragmentation, relocation, and re-formation. The Guinea case demonstrated that removal from one location did not end mobilization; related activity later re-formed around a politically significant secondary location. [1]

7. Lived Case Study: UNGA 81, New York City

UNGA 81 provided a concentrated comparative environment in which multiple diaspora and advocacy networks used the same diplomatic geography for very different political objectives. The field collection included Guinea, Liberia, Haiti, Bangladesh, North Korea-focused advocacy, and a Philippines/Pax Silica coalition.[1]

7.1 Guinea: Polarized Confrontation and Re-formation

- Observe: sustained organized mobilization, recurring FNDC-associated imagery, red apparel, chants, political signs, extensive phone recording, counter-presence, restricted urban geometry, and visible NYPD presence.
- Orient: the event progressed from Demonstration/Protest through Expressive Friction into Dynamic Confrontation. The critical shift came from proximity, compression, and direct interaction between politically opposed actors, not merely from loud rhetoric.[1][2]
- Decide: field priorities shifted from grievance collection to police posture, spillover potential, safe distance, and tracking movement during dispersal.
- Act and re-observe: field notes recorded a physical confrontation during dispersal, NYPD intervention and escort/removal activity, and later re-formation around the Waldorf Astoria/Guinea delegation area.[1]
- Analytical lesson: polarization and movement trajectory were more informative than turnout. The overall evidence did not establish sustained riot-level behavior.

7.2 Liberia: Political Deliberation Rather Than Civil Disorder

- Observe: prolonged face-to-face political debate, animated gestures, competing interpretations, but no comparable police separation line, barricade pressure, or sustained physical confrontation.

- Orient: Passive Assembly to Expressive Friction. The central intelligence requirement was narrative competition, not confrontation prediction.[1]
- Analytical lesson: strong political disagreement can remain civic and discursive. Diaspora sentiment should not be treated as a single national position.

7.3 Haiti, Bangladesh, North Korea, and Pax Silica

Haiti: Sovereignty / foreign-intervention grievance. The observed messaging challenged U.S./UN involvement, illustrating that the international institution hosting a protest can itself be part of the grievance target.[1]

Bangladesh: Narrative plurality. Minority-rights advocacy and leadership-centered political currents appeared in the same broader protest environment. The correct unit of analysis is actor/network, not nationality alone.[1]

North Korea-focused advocacy: Target-specific external accountability. Severe human-rights and institutional messaging was present, but observed interaction risk was comparatively low. Message severity did not equal crowd risk.[1]

Pax Silica / Philippines: Coalition mobilization. Land, water, AI infrastructure, war, foreign investment, and sovereignty were connected under a shared mobilizing narrative. The key variable was network architecture rather than direct confrontation.[1]

8. Comparative Analysis of Documented Events

Case	Core grievance	Political frame	Mobilization	Interaction risk	Observed phase
Guinea	Transition legitimacy; detainee/disappearance; governance	Regime legitimacy / human rights	High	High at peak	Expressive Friction → Dynamic Confrontation
Liberia	Governance performance; accountability	Performance legitimacy	Moderate	Low-Moderate	Passive → Expressive Friction
Haiti	Foreign intervention / sovereignty	National sovereignty	Moderate	Low observed	Passive / Expressive
Bangladesh	Minority rights + political loyalty	Rights + partisan legitimacy	Moderate	Low observed	Passive / Expressive
North Korea advocacy	Human rights / regime accountability	External accountability	Low-Moderate	Low	Passive Assembly
Pax Silica / Philippines	Land, water, AI, militarization, sovereignty	Resource sovereignty	Moderate-High	Low-Moderate	Expressive Friction

9. Four Functional Models of Political Events

Model A: Polarized Confrontation | Guinea

Two or more competing political constituencies occupy the same space. Primary concern: interaction risk.

Model B: Political Deliberation | Liberia

Participants contest interpretations within a shared national political space. Primary concern: narrative competition.

Model C: Advocacy Demonstration | North Korea-focused advocacy; portions of Bangladesh

Participants seek visibility for a specific grievance or demand. Primary concern: message, target, and evidence.

Model D: Coalition Mobilization | Pax Silica / transnational advocacy

Multiple grievances are integrated into a shared mobilizing narrative. Primary concern: network architecture and issue convergence.

10. MNS Field Analyst Collection Card

EVENT	Date/time/location; country/issue; actor/network.
OBSERVE	Crowd size/density; slogans; movement; opposition; police posture; media/digital activity; egress.
ORIENT	Event type; crowd phase; grievance; target; demand; legitimacy frame; mobilization intensity; interaction risk.
DECIDE	Field state 1-5; 5×5 operational risk; collection priority; safety boundary; next trigger.
ACT	Hold/reposition/withdraw; photo/video/audio; follow movement; document security changes; record dispersal; reassess.
TRIGGERS	Counter-protest arrival; police reinforcement; physical contact; route change; leader/convoy arrival; dispersal order; crowd fragmentation; secondary-location movement.

11. Evidence Discipline and After-Action Review

- Distinguish direct observation from inference and attributed claims. A sign, chant, or participant statement establishes what was communicated, not whether the claim is true.
- Record time and trajectory. The value of field notes increases when they show how risk changes rather than simply how an event looked at one moment.

- Preserve original files and note duplicates. Video is strongest for behavior and movement; still photography is strongest for message coding; handwritten notes preserve temporal judgments not recoverable after the fact.
- Reassess after dispersal. Track whether groups terminate, fragment, relocate, or re-form around a new target.
- Conduct an after-action comparison against the initial assessment. Identify what changed, which indicators mattered, which assumptions failed, and which field positions created or reduced risk.

12. Conclusion

The field analyst's advantage comes from disciplined adaptation. Political protest environments are dynamic systems in which identity, grievance, space, counter-presence, police posture, digital amplification, and movement interact continuously. The UNGA 81 cases demonstrate that the most useful intelligence is often found in transitions: mobilization to convergence, disagreement to hostility, containment to dispersal, and dispersal to re-formation.

The OODA-Risk model provides a practical discipline for following those transitions without collapsing political intensity into violence or treating every crowd as a single actor. Used consistently, it produces safer collection, clearer evidentiary separation, more defensible risk assessments, and better comparative analysis across political events.

References

- [1] Shakoore, M. N. (2026). M. Nuri Shakoore field notes from UNGA 81 protests. Unpublished contemporaneous field notes and evidence package, New York City.
- [2] Operational Analysis of Public Assemblies, Crowd Psychology, Civil Unrest, and Strategic Public Order Frameworks. (2026). MNS Consulting-provided analytical reference.
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